

A Grumpy 2 Corinthians 9

2 Corinthians 9 — as received by the grumpy heart / the refuser

Not Scripture — what the chapter sounds like to someone who hears obligation where Paul speaks grace.

Creative reading exercise. Paul's chapter, read with a willing heart, is liberation: give freely, God supplies, the saints eat, God gets glory. Read with a grumpy heart, the same words become a ledger, a reputation, and a threat.

The collection (again)

Now it is **superfluous** for him to write — and yet here is another letter about money.

He says he need not write about the ministry for the saints. **Then he writes anyway.** That is the whole pattern: praise first, pressure second, theology third — to soften the invoice.

He knows our “readiness.” He has **boasted about us to Macedonia** — told other churches how generous Achaia is, how we have been ready since last year, how our zeal has stirred them up. So we are not merely giving; we are **props in his travel narrative**. If we delay, we do not merely disappoint the poor. We embarrass the apostle who already told everyone we were good for it.

He is sending brothers — not to help us worship, but **so his boasting does not prove empty**. Arrange the gift in advance, he says. Be ready. Do not make him look foolish when Macedonians arrive with him to audit our hearts.

And the gift must be **willing**, not an exaction.

The grumpy heart hears:

“You promised. I told people you promised. Send it before I get there so I am not humiliated — and so you are not humiliated — and call it willing.”

The cheerful giver (on compulsory terms)

The point is this — and the grumpy heart has heard this point before, in every sermon that ends near the offering plate:

Whoever sows sparingly reaps sparingly.

Whoever sows bountifully reaps bountifully.

Translation:

Hold back, and God will hold back on you. Give big, and maybe God gives big back. The field is not Jerusalem's hungry saints alone. The field is **your ledger**.

Each one must give as he has decided in his heart — **not reluctantly or under compulsion**.

The grumpy heart answers:

Then stop sending brothers ahead of you. Stop boasting about my readiness to churches I have never met. Stop timing your visit so that “decided in the heart” means **decided before the Macedonians show up to compare us with themselves**. A cheerful giver does not need auditors.

God loves a cheerful giver.

The grumpy heart hears accusation, not promise:

If my face is tight when I write the check, I am not only poor — I am **unloved**. Cheerfulness is not fruit of the Spirit here; it is **currency**.

Grace that still feels like a contract

God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that having all sufficiency in all things at all times, you may abound in every good work.

The grumpy heart hears a bargain:

First sufficiency, then overflow — **if** the pipeline runs through generosity on demand. Grace abounds, but it abounds **toward more giving**. Even blessing has a work order attached.

As it is written:

“He has distributed freely, he has given to the poor; his righteousness endures forever.”

The grumpy heart mutters:

Yes — **freely**. That is what the righteous man did. I am now being quoted a psalm about a man I am supposed to become **on schedule**, with witnesses en route from Macedonia.

He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness.

The grumpy heart hears:

God will **restock you** — seed for more sowing, not merely bread for your table. The harvest measured is **righteousness**, which in this letter is curiously weighed in denarii.

You will be enriched in every way to be generous in every way, which through us will produce thanksgiving to God.

There it is.

Enriched **to** be generous. Thanksgiving **through us** — through the apostle's collection route. My wallet becomes his doxology.

What the service really accomplishes (to a cynical ear)

The ministry of this service is not only supplying the needs of the saints —

The grumpy heart concedes:

fine, the saints need food.

— but is also overflowing in many thanksgivings to God.

And also:

many thanksgivings **to the giver's church** for being the kind of church Paul can boast about.

By their approval of this service, they will glorify God because of your **submission** that comes from your confession of the gospel of Christ, and the generosity of your contribution for them and for all others —

The grumpy heart stiffens at “submission.”

Confession of the gospel, and then a test with brothers traveling ahead to confirm the confession cleared the bank. Generosity for **them and for all others** — the circle widens; the hand does not.

While they long for you and pray for you, because of the surpassing grace of God upon you.

The grumpy heart hears:

They do not long for **us**. They long for **what arrived when we complied**. They pray because grace “surpassed” — and grace, in this chapter, keeps wearing our signature.

Thanks be to God for his inexpressible gift!

The grumpy heart, at the last line:

Christ? The gospel? Yes — **inexpressible**.

But after nine verses of seed, harvest, readiness, and arranged gifts, the inexpressible gift feels like the bow on a package that was never optional.

What the refuser actually receives

Not the promise Paul intends. Not sufficiency, not joy, not the harvest of righteousness.

The grumpy heart receives:

- **Exposure** — already advertised to Macedonia
- **A deadline** — dressed as eagerness
- **A moral score** — cheerful or unloved
- **A theology of return** — sow big, reap big, or explain your small faith
- **Submission language** — gospel confession tied to a transfer
- **Other people's prayers** — triggered by our performance

And so the refuser closes the letter **already poorer in spirit**, whether or not he opens his purse — because he heard not “God loves a cheerful giver,” but:

“Everyone knows you’re ready. Don’t make us ashamed. Give like you mean it, or admit you never meant the gospel you confess.”

The refuser does not receive the gift of 9:15. He receives the echo of 9:4 — **humiliation** — and carries it back into his own chest, unpaid.